A short bespectacled man with steely eyes and rigid posture, Honecker hailed from working-class stock and grew up in the totalitarian ideologies of the twentieth century – first as a victim and then a perpetrator.

Remarkably, he managed to survive a decade of imprisonment in a Nazi jail and emerged unscathed from the Second World War and the 1953 uprising against communist rule in East Germany. Over time, he became Walter Ulbricht's hatchet man, carrying out a purge of progressive functionaries.

Though well-read with rigorous political indoctrination, Honecker lacked formal education and observers considered him an unassuming functionary, unaware of his vital role in constructing the Berlin Wall.

Although frequently on the verge of being relegated to obscurity, he managed to overthrow Ulbricht in 1971 and set his stamp on German politics.

He was a stubborn man who claimed to understand the East German people. Beneath his affable exterior, there was a character of infinite guile.

Walter Ulbricht was only the first to fall before him. Honecker's agents unintentionally secured the demise of West German leader Willy Brandt, and he outwitted his political master Leonid Brezhnev with the greatest of ease.

However, some things can be set unarguably to his credit.

In foreign affairs, he secured the recognition of East Germany, signed the Helsinki Accords, and eased tensions with the West. Although his motto, 'Vorwärts immer, rückwärts nimmer' (Always look forward, never look back), made for a great rallying cry, Honecker's failures and omissions were legendary. Shortages were common, political liberties virtually non-existent, as was the freedom to travel.

During his historic visit to West Germany in 1987, as perestroika and glasnost swept across the socialist world, Honecker commented that 'socialism and capitalism can be no more united than fire and water'. But his downfall was always on the cards once the new openness devised by his